The First Line

The execution log stops at 3:47 in the afternoon. No red text. No traceback. Just a clean terminal and one number at the bottom of the screen, like something I have reached through a wall and pulled out. For a few seconds, the room holds still.

The desk is from primary school. My mother bought it when I was seven: white laminate over particleboard, with one corner now peeling upward. A faded blue bear sticker clings near the left edge. My knees no longer fit underneath, so I sit angled to the right, one foot braced on the chair rung.

I scroll up. Down. Open the visualization, close it, and open it again.

The model still has weaknesses; I can already see what I will revise. But the entire pipeline has run from beginning to end. I built it here, at this undersized desk, and the first person I want to show is my mother. I want more than encouragement. I want her to understand what she is looking at.

That evening, I hear the key in the lock.

My mother comes in the way she always does: bag first, then her shoulder, then the small negotiation with the door latch. She sets her keys on the counter and leaves the overhead light off, moving through the apartment by memory. A horizontal crease runs across the back of her uniform. I wonder whether she sat down at all.

I wait until she has put her bag down. "Mom," I say. "Come look at this."

She comes over without taking off her shoes, unusual for her. She leans over my shoulder, and I tilt the monitor toward her.

"It finally ran," I say. "The whole thing. The data cleaning, the model, the output. This line means it finished without crashing."

She looks at the screen for a real moment. Her chin dips slightly. She stays longer than I expect, reading the terminal with the earnestness of someone looking through a language for a word they might recognize.

“真棒,” she says. (That's wonderful.)

Her hand rests briefly on my shoulder, then drops.

“但是妈妈看不懂啊.” (But Mom doesn't understand it.)

Her voice stays soft.

For a moment, I keep my hand on the mouse. The cursor is still resting beside the final line. I want to scroll upward, to find an earlier line, a simpler one, something that could carry months of work out of the screen and into the room.

But I know the first line would explain even less.

I do not move.

She turns toward the kitchen, and the apartment begins moving again.

The terminal is still open. The output has not changed. The fan runs at the same low pitch it has all afternoon. At the edge of my vision, the faded bear is still fixed to the desk my mother bought when I was seven.

I lower the monitor brightness.

Outside, the street sounds continue. She opens the refrigerator, and something clinks inside it. I scroll the terminal back to the top, as if the first line might explain it better.